Barbara Zá Franks, EdD

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

AI learning product and education executive with 18 years of experience across K–12, EdTech, international education, curriculum and assessment, learning analytics, and academic leadership. Combines learning science, standards-based design, data-driven decision-making, and technical fluency to build and scale AI-powered learning products. Currently leads Language Arts and Vocabulary programs across 50+ Alpha Schools campuses, with ownership spanning curriculum, assessment, intervention, analytics, and AI-generated learning systems. Former Chief Academic Officer and multi-campus education leader with experience across the United States, China, and the Caribbean.

CORE EXPERTISE

AI Learning Products & EdTech | Learning Product Strategy | Learning Science | Curriculum Architecture
Assessment Design & Validation| Learning Analytics | AI-Generated Learning Content | AI-Graded Open Response
Adaptive & Mastery-Based Learning | Intervention Systems| Data-Driven Personalization | Product Evaluation
Standards & Competency Mapping | Cross-Functional Leadership | Program Scaling

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

AI-Driven English Language Arts Learning Strategist | Curriculum DRI 12/2025 – present
2-HOUR LEARNING / ALPHA SCHOOLS| Austin, TX (Remote)

- Own Language Arts programming across Grades K–12 for 50+ Alpha Schools campuses, with responsibility spanning curriculum, assessment, analytics, intervention, and learning-product development.
- Serve as Directly Responsible Individual (DRI) for Grades 3–8 Language Arts and PreK–12 Vocabulary, leading program strategy, product requirements, quality assurance, and cross-functional implementation.
- Designed and launched a proprietary Grades 7–12 vocabulary program covering 1,800 words, with interactive instruction, AI-graded sentence production, and escalating spaced-retrieval assessments.
- Built five standards-aligned Language intervention courses for Grades 3–7 comprising 209 components, 974 subskill lessons, and approximately 35,490 assessment items, all developed to a defined rigor specification.
- Designed standardized Language and Vocabulary assessments across elementary, middle, and high school using multiple QTI response formats, grade-banded DOK expectations, passage specifications, and AI-graded and auto-scored production items.
- Created a proprietary cross-program vocabulary registry serving as the source of truth for 3,964 words, 4,230 word senses, and 8,531 course placements across proprietary vocabulary and test-preparation programs, including ISEE and SAT.
- Architected sense-level definitions and metadata, including frequency, age-of-acquisition, and syllable data, and published reusable JSON/CSV services to support consistent use across curriculum and product teams.
- Developed approximately 70 multi-part ELA lessons across Language and Writing and led the transition from manually assembled content to versioned, auto-graded, specification-driven learning objects.
- Designed live analytics dashboards tracking enrollment, testing, mastery, stalled progress, learner efficiency, standards coverage, item performance, and individual learner profiles.
- Identified and resolved data-quality issues materially affecting program reporting, including pseudo-records inflating attempts by approximately 21%, missing test-source data, recoverable null scores, and grade-level logic obscuring intervention eligibility.
- Rebuilt learner-data ingestion using the live gradebook API after diagnosing warehouse exclusions, increasing question-to-assessment linkage from 606 to 1,099 of 1,125 line items.
- Analyzed a 3,530-student vocabulary baseline, identifying 45% of learners below grade level and 31% two or more grade levels below, and translated findings into targeted intervention and placement strategies.
- Led vocabulary program efficacy analysis linking learner activity to NWEA MAP growth using per-student growth windows, residual modeling against expected growth, activity controls, and campus fixed-effects checks; identified

an approximately 1.3 RIT association in Reading per standard deviation of vocabulary XP, reported as correlational with potential confounding explicitly documented.
- Built individualized Language intervention plans for Grades 3–9 using assessment misses, mastery data, priority rules, and XP-based completion forecasting.
- Developed an intervention-support system mapping recent assessment misses to targeted instructional plans and adapted vocabulary lists drawn from a 182-list content catalog.
- Diagnosed a construct-validity issue in which vocabulary knowledge gaps were being misclassified as context-clue strategy gaps, then specified a replacement model using word-level attribution, targeted intervention, and a mastery gate.
- Recalibrated Grades 7–12 vocabulary bands using age-of-acquisition norms, word frequency, and live learner accuracy data, and redesigned the instructional sequence around five phases: Meaning, Accuracy, Appropriacy, Word Parts, and Assess.
- Collaborate across learning science, reading, product, engineering, campus leadership, and instructional teams to translate evidence into product, curriculum, and intervention decisions.

Chief Research Officer (Fractional / Consulting) 04/2025 – present
VIRTUOUS SEA CORPORATION| Irvine, CA (Remote)
- Lead applied research strategy focused on international education, workforce development, international student outcomes, employer behavior, and labor-market trends.
- Design quantitative and qualitative research studies, including survey instruments, research protocols, regression analyses, and mixed-methods research.
- Develop the organization's multi-year research agenda and translate findings into actionable recommendations for education institutions, employers, industry partners, and policymakers.
- Lead development of proprietary research frameworks, dashboards, reports, white papers, industry presentations, and research publications.
- Supervise research collaborators and establish standards for methodological rigor, research ethics, data integrity, and dissemination.

EXECUTIVE EDUCATION LEADERSHIP

Chief Academic Officer | Regional Dean |Principal & Academic Dean | Dean of Faculty 03/2019 – 06/2025
KNOWLEDGELINK /BARSTOW SCHOOLS / ST. MARY'S ONLINE ACADEMY | Boston, MA (Remote)
- Progressed through increasingly senior academic leadership positions within an international education organization operating American K–12 programs, online education, and multi-campus schools in China.
- Served as Chief Academic Officer for a multi-campus international education network, directing academic strategy, curriculum, accreditation, faculty systems, school development, and academic quality assurance.
- Directed academic and operational management across eight campuses serving more than 1,200 students.
- Led academic leadership for a middle and high school campus serving 900+ students, supervising deans, department heads, faculty, academic scheduling, policies, and school-improvement initiatives.
- Directed academic operations for an online U.S. high school diploma program serving international students.
- Oversaw curriculum development, academic program evaluation, accreditation readiness, instructional quality, and expansion into new education markets.
- Designed and implemented cross-campus academic policies, curriculum standards, faculty evaluation systems, professional-development programs, course catalogs, and student handbooks.
- Used assessment and student-performance data to identify program weaknesses, guide instructional decisions, and support institutional improvement.
- Recruited, supervised, coached, and evaluated academic leaders and faculty across multiple campuses and disciplines.
- Led consulting projects supporting new-school launches, education-product development, academic-program design, and international partnerships.

Founder and Principal Consultant 08/2023 - present
D.R.E.A.M. EDUCATION SOLUTIONS | Freeport, The Bahamas

- Founded an international education and EdTech consultancy developing academic programs, institutional partnerships, and technology-enabled education solutions.
- Develop AI-enabled education products and prototypes spanning curriculum authoring, teacher productivity, learner personalization, educational analytics, and recruitment.
- Designed dual-diploma programs, early-college pathways, curriculum systems, academic policies, and institutional onboarding models for international partners.
- Build education partnerships across the Caribbean, Africa, Asia, Central America, and the United States.

Head of School 07/2022 – 07/2023
OMOLOLU INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL | Anguilla, British West Indies

- Directed strategic, academic, and operational leadership for a K–8 IB Primary Years Programme school.
- Led faculty development, curriculum improvement, data analysis, family engagement, staffing, and resource allocation.
- Used student-performance evidence to guide instructional priorities and school-improvement initiatives.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Instructional Coach & Curriculum Developer (Independent Contractor) 12/2017 – 11/2019
NEW STAGE SUBJECT ENGLISH | Shanghai, China

Startup Founder 07/2016 – 12/2019
SHANGHAI D.R.E.A.M. EDUCATION TECHNOLOGY CO., LTD. | Shanghai, China

Elementary Teacher 08/2011 – 06/2016
SHANGHAI PINGHE BILINGUAL SCHOOL | Shanghai, China

Music Teacher (Part-Time) 09/2007 – 06/2008
ST. ANDREW'S ANGLICAN SCHOOL | Exuma, Bahamas

Startup Founder & Music Teacher 07/2007 – 07/2011
CENTER STAGE PERFORMING ARTS STUDIO | Exuma, Bahamas

Human Resources Coordinator 03/2006 – 06/2007
FOUR SEASONS RESORT GREAT EXUMA | Exuma, Bahamas

Administrative Assistant & Music Teacher 01/2005 – 02/2006
THE EDUCATION CENTRE | Grand Bahama, Bahamas

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

Doctor of Education (EdD) in Leadership 06/2025
AMERICAN COLLEGE OF EDUCATION | Indianapolis, IN
Dissertation Title: The Influence of Leadership Behaviors on Teacher Retention: A Basic Qualitative Study

Post-Baccalaureate Teaching Certification 10/2016
MORELAND UNIVERSITY | Washington, DC

Earned District of Columbia (Washington, DC) Elementary Education Certification

Master of Education (MEd) in Educational Leadership 12/2014
AMERICAN COLLEGE OF EDUCATION | Indianapolis, IN
Earned District of Columbia (Washington, DC) Administrative Services (K-12 Principal/Assistant Principal) Certification

Bachelor of Arts (BA) in International Relations 12/2004
LYNN UNIVERSITY | Boca Raton, FL

TECHNICAL FLUENCY & EDTECH STANDARDS

Technical Fluency (AI-Assisted Development)	Python | SQL | Postgres | Flask | Vercel | Remotion | REST APIs | OAuth
EdTech Standards & Data Integration	QTI 3 | OneRoster 1.2 | CASE | Content & Progression APIs
Learning & Assessment Frameworks	CCSS | TEKS/STAAR | NWEA MAP/RIT | AP | Bloom's Taxonomy | Webb's DOK